

26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit



For Prelims: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) , Collective Security Treaty Organization , African Union , China-Pakistan Economic Corridor , Belt and Road Initiative , Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)

For Mains: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO): Evolution, objectives, structure and significance, India's role in the SCO and its relevance to India's strategic autonomy, Role of international and regional organisations in promoting a multipolar global order.

Source: AIR

Why in News?

The **26 th Meeting of the Council of Heads of State (CHS)** of the **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)** and the inaugural **"SCO Plus"** meeting were held in **Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan** .

- Marking the **25 th anniversary** of the SCO, the summit was chaired by Kyrgyzstan under the theme , *"25 Years of the SCO: Together for Sustainable Peace, Development and Prosperity."*

Summary

- The **26th SCO Summit in Bishkek** strengthened cooperation in **regional security, counter-terrorism, connectivity, technology, environment and economic development** , while adopting several institutional and cooperation measures.
- For **India** , the SCO remains an important platform to advance **strategic autonomy, Central Asian connectivity, counter-terrorism and multi-alignment** , while promoting a more **multipolar world order** .

What are the Key Outcomes of the 26th SCO Summit in Kyrgyzstan?

- **Bishkek Declaration:** The SCO leaders **signed and issued the Bishkek Declaration** , reaffirming

cooperation on regional peace, security, development and the organisation's future direction.

- **SCO Charter Amendments:** The leaders **approved the Protocol on Amendments and Additions to the SCO Charter** , aimed at updating the organisation's institutional framework.
 - It allows newer members, such as India, to actively participate in shaping the organization's future structural and legal framework.
- **Universal Security Centre:** The SCO leaders **approved the regulations to establish the Universal Centre for Countering Challenges and Threats to the Security of SCO Member States**.
 - This aims to enhance intelligence sharing against terrorism, extremism, and organized crime.
- **SCO Anti-Drug Centre:** The leaders **approved the regulations on the Executive Committee of the SCO Anti-Drug Centre** and adopted programmes on **combating drug addiction** and **countering the spread of synthetic drugs and their precursors up to 2030** .
- **Economic & Green Corridors:** Leaders signed an action plan for the development **of ports and logistics centers across member states (2026-2030)** and established the framework for the **SCO "Green Technology Corridor"** .
- **Global Institutional Partnerships:** The summit approved the **SCO-CSTO-CIS Roadmap** for trilateral cooperation among the **SCO, Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO), and Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS)**.
 - It also decided to sign a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the SCO Secretariat and the **African Union Commission**, further expanding the SCO's engagement with regional organisations.
- **International Information Security:** The SCO **adopted a Plan of Cooperation on Ensuring International Information Security for 2026-2028** .
- **Biodiversity:** The leaders adopted an initiative on the **Conservation and Sustainable Management of Biodiversity in SCO Member States for 2026-2031** , along with a joint action plan.
- **Pakistan's Chairmanship:** The **rotating SCO chairmanship for 2026-2027 was handed over to Pakistan** , which announced the theme **"Turning Vision into Action: Connectivity, Innovation and Shared Prosperity"** for its tenure.
 - **Lahore was also designated as the SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital for 2026-2027** .

India at 26th SCO Summit

- **Three Pillars of Engagement:** India's Prime Minister outlined **three core pillars** for the SCO's future: **Security, Connectivity, and Opportunity** .
- **Dismantling the Terror Ecosystem:** India strongly called for a unified approach to **counter-terrorism** , urging member states to dismantle the financing and safe havens of terrorism without employing **"double standards"** .
 - Addressing global geopolitical conflicts, India reiterated its steadfast position that **conflicts cannot be resolved on the battlefield** ; dialogue and diplomacy are the only way forward.
- **Sovereignty in Connectivity:** India stressed that all connectivity projects must **respect the sovereignty and territorial integrity of nations** (a clear, a principled, indirect critique of **China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** and the **China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)**).
- **Indian-Led Initiatives:**
 - **Youth and Innovation:** The SCO **endorsed India's initiatives** to strengthen scientific and technical cooperation through the **SCO Young Scientists Forum** and **SCO Young Authors Conference** .
 - **Civilisational Dialogue:** Member states **welcomed India's initiative to host the first SCO Civilisation Dialogue Forum in 2026** .

- **Language Reform:** During **India's 2022-23 SCO Presidency**, India proposed adding **English** as an official and working language. The **26th SCO Summit** added English alongside **Russian and Chinese**.

"SCO Plus" Format

- **About:** The "SCO Plus" is an expanded multilateral dialogue mechanism that includes non-member states and international organisations to discuss global challenges and multipolarity.
- **Theme for 2026:** *"The UN as a Key Element of a Just World Order: The Contribution of the SCO Plus States to the Formation of a Multipolar World."*

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)

- **About:** The SCO is a permanent **intergovernmental international organization**, created in 2001 in Shanghai (China). It was preceded by the **Shanghai Five** (China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan) **mechanism**.
- **Significance:** With the membership of 10 countries, the SCO represents a vast geopolitical space, accounting for approximately **25% of the global GDP** and over 40% of the world's population.
- **Member States:** China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, India, Pakistan, Iran, and Belarus (the newest member).
- **Observer States:** Afghanistan and Mongolia.
- **Dialogue Partners:** Azerbaijan, Armenia, Bahrain, Egypt, Cambodia, Qatar, Kuwait, Laos, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, UAE, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Sri Lanka.
- **Secretariat:** Beijing, China.
- **Core Objectives:** To strengthen mutual trust, maintain regional peace, security, and stability, and jointly address new challenges—primarily the **"Three Evils" of Terrorism, Separatism, and Extremism**.
- **Structure:**
 - **Heads of State Council (HSC):** The supreme decision-making body of the SCO.
 - **Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS):** Headquartered in Tashkent (Uzbekistan), **RATS** is a permanent organ of the SCO that coordinates efforts of member states against terrorism, separatism, and extremism.

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)

Founding Members (2001):

Recent Members:



Key Facts:

- **Established:** 2001, in Shanghai, China
- **Charter Signed:** 2002; came into force on 19th September 2003
- **Goals:**
 - Strengthen regional peace, stability, & cooperation
 - Combat terrorism, separatism, & extremism
 - Foster economic, political, & cultural collaboration
- **Structure**
 - **Supreme Decision-making Body** - Council of Heads of State
 - **Permanent Bodies** - Secretariat (Beijing) & Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (Tashkent)
- **Official Languages:** Russian & Chinese
- **Headquarters:** Beijing, China
- **SCO & India:** Varanasi has been nominated as the first ever SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital at the SCO summit in Samarkand, 2022



Why is the SCO Significant for India?

- **Security and Counter-Terrorism:** Through the **RATS mechanism**, India gains access to intelligence sharing and joint counter-terrorism exercises, which is crucial for securing its borders and combatting cross-border terrorism emanating from its neighborhood.
- **Connect Central Asia Policy:** The SCO provides a direct diplomatic and economic gateway to the resource-rich **Central Asian Republics (CARs)**, a region where India lacks direct land access.
 - Central Asian nations (like Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan) are rich in hydrocarbons and uranium. Active participation in the SCO allows India to secure its long-term energy needs.
- **Balancing Strategic Autonomy:** Engaging in the SCO (which includes China and Russia) while simultaneously being a core member of the Quad (with the US, Japan, and Australia) allows India to successfully exercise its policy of **multi-alignment and strategic autonomy** in a multipolar world.

What are the Key Challenges Facing the SCO and Measures to Address Them?

Area	Key Challenge for the SCO	Way Forward
Decision-Making	The SCO works largely through consensus . India-Pakistan tensions and India-China border disputes can therefore make it difficult to reach common decisions.	Develop confidence-building and dispute-management mechanisms within the SCO so that bilateral tensions do not block cooperation.
Geopolitical Balance	The growing influence of China and Russia , along with the inclusion of Iran and Belarus, creates a perception of the SCO as an anti-Western grouping . This can conflict with India's policy of strategic autonomy .	Preserve the SCO as a non-bloc and inclusive platform , rather than allowing it to become aligned against any particular power or group.
Terrorism & Security	The SCO's RATS mainly facilitates coordination and intelligence sharing but has limited capacity for enforcing collective action . Differences among members can also lead to inconsistent approaches towards terrorism.	Strengthen RATS through better intelligence sharing, common databases, coordinated action against terror financing and stronger implementation mechanisms.
Economic Cooperation	China's much larger economy gives it considerable influence within the SCO. Smaller economies may face trade imbalances and excessive dependence on Chinese capital and markets.	Promote balanced economic cooperation , including equitable financing mechanisms and greater trade among all member states.
Connectivity	Eurasian connectivity is divided among competing initiatives such as China's BRI, India's INSTC and Trans-Caspian routes . Different customs procedures and geopolitical concerns further slow connectivity.	Develop interoperable transport corridors , harmonise customs procedures and promote connectivity projects that respect the sovereignty of member states .

Conclusion

The SCO can play a meaningful role in shaping a **multipolar and just world order** only if it moves beyond internal bilateral disputes, addresses terrorism through consistent standards, and focuses on practical cooperation. For India, the SCO remains a vital **Eurasian platform** to preserve **strategic autonomy** , strengthen connectivity with Central Asia, and advance its economic and security interests.

Drishti Mains Question:

Can the SCO emerge as an effective pillar of a multipolar world order without becoming an anti-Western bloc? Critically examine.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the SCO?

The **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation** is a permanent intergovernmental organisation established in **2001 in Shanghai** , preceded by the Shanghai Five mechanism.

2. What are the core security objectives of the SCO?

The SCO focuses on regional peace, security and stability, particularly combating the **Three Evils: Terrorism, Separatism and Extremism** .

3. What is the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)?

RATS , headquartered in Tashkent, is a permanent SCO organ that coordinates member states' efforts against **terrorism, separatism and extremism** .

4. What is the significance of the SCO Plus format?

The **SCO Plus** expands dialogue to non-member states and international organisations, focusing on global challenges and the **formation of a multipolar world order** .

5. Why is the SCO important for India?

It provides India with a platform for **counter-terrorism cooperation, Central Asian engagement, energy security and connectivity** , while supporting its policy of **strategic autonomy and multi-alignment** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/wP64qBEyYGo>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following: (2022)

1. Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank
2. Missile Technology Control Regime
3. Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

India is a member of which of the above?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (d)

Q. Belt and Road Initiative' is sometimes mentioned in the news in the context of the affairs of (2016)

- (a) African Union
- (b) Brazil
- (c) European Union
- (d) China

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India? (2021)

Q. The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) is viewed as a cardinal subset of China's larger 'One Belt One Road' initiative. Give a brief description of CPEC and enumerate the reasons why India has distanced itself from the same. (2018)

Q. China and Pakistan have entered into an agreement for the development of an economic corridor. What threat does this pose for India's security? Critically examine. (2014)

Q. "China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia". In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbour. (2017)

Interim Government of 1946



Why in News?

2nd September marks the anniversary of the formation of the **Interim Government of India in 1946** , headed by **Jawaharlal Nehru** . It was the first institutional framework where Indian leaders took **executive charge of British India** , marking a pivotal milestone in the formal transfer of power leading to **independence on 15 th August 1947**.

What was the Interim Government of 1946?

- **Background and Genesis:** Following **World War II** , economic exhaustion and mutinies (such as the **Royal Indian Navy Mutiny of 1946**) compelled the British government under **Clement Attlee** to accelerate the transfer of power.
- **Cabinet Mission Plan (1946):** Dispatched in March 1946, the Cabinet Mission was headed by **Lord Pethick-Lawrence** (Secretary of State for India), with **Sir Stafford Cripps** (President of the Board of Trade) and **A.V. Alexander** (First Lord of the Admiralty) as its other members.
 - The **Cabinet Mission Plan (1946)** rejected the demand for **Pakistan** and proposed a **three-tier federal structure (Union, Section and Provincial levels)** , with provinces grouped into **three sections: Section A (Hindu-majority provinces), Section B (Muslim-majority provinces), and Section C (Bengal and Assam)** .
 - It provided for a **389-member Constituent Assembly** , and the Plan also provided for the **lapse of British paramountcy over princely states** and the formation of an **Interim Government** during the transition to independence.
- **Interim Government:** The Interim Government was a provisional administration formed to manage executive functions and assist in the transition from British colonial rule to independence.
 - **Cabinet System:** Intended to operate as a **cabinet government** , rather than merely a collection of departmental heads under the Viceroy.
 - **Key Objectives:** Prepare India for independence, coordinate the transfer of power, and facilitate the functioning of the Constituent Assembly.
- **Legal Framework:** It functioned under the existing **Government of India Act, 1919** , through the restructured **Viceroy's Executive Council** . The **Viceroy remained the formal constitutional head** , while **Indian leaders were expected to exercise real executive authority** .
- **Leadership:** The **Viceroy (Lord Wavell)** remained the ex-officio **President** of the Executive Council.
 - **Jawaharlal Nehru** was appointed as the **Vice-President of the Executive Council** , effectively acting as the de facto Prime Minister and head of internal administration.
- **Direct Action Day:** While the Indian National Congress agreed to join, negotiations broke down over grouping clauses and communal representation.
 - The **All-India Muslim League** withdrew its acceptance and launched '**Direct Action Day**' (**16 th August 1946**) , triggering widespread communal riots, notably the Great Calcutta Killings.
 - Despite the turmoil and the Muslim League's initial boycott, Viceroy Wavell invited Jawaharlal Nehru to form the administration, which officially took office on **2 nd September 1946**.
- **Entry of Muslim League:** Realizing that staying out marginalized its influence, the Muslim League joined the Interim Government on 26 th October 1946, without withdrawing its rejection of the **Cabinet Mission Plan or renouncing Direct Action**.

- Three Congress members resigned to accommodate five League nominees. **Liaquat Ali Khan** was appointed as the Finance Member, where he used financial powers to obstruct several Congress-led initiatives.
- Significance of the Interim Government:**
 - Independent Foreign Policy:** Nehru laid the foundations for **non-alignment** and independent diplomacy.
 - Princely States:** Addressed relations with **princely states** and laid the groundwork for their **future integration into the Indian Union**, with a coordinated mechanism considered necessary during the transition.
 - Indianisation of Administration:** Began transferring control of the **civil services, police and armed forces** to Indian leaders.
 - Governing Experience:** Indian leaders gained experience in **administration, food management and developmental planning**.
 - Realization of the Inevitability of Partition:** The paralysis within the Interim Government convinced leaders like Sardar Patel and Jawaharlal Nehru that an unworkable coalition at the Centre would lead to continuous civil strife, paving the way for the acceptance of the **Lord Mountbatten's Partition Plan (3 rd June 1947)**.

Interim Government (1946)

Sl. No.	Members	Portfolios Held
1.	Jawaharlal Nehru	Vice-President of the Council; External Affairs & Commonwealth Relations
2.	Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel	Home, Information & Broadcasting
3.	Dr. Rajendra Prasad	Food & Agriculture
4.	Dr. John Mathai	Industries & Supplies
5.	Jagjivan Ram	Labour
6.	Sardar Baldev Singh	Defence
7.	C.H. Bhabha	Works, Mines & Power
8.	Liaquat Ali Khan	Finance
9.	Abdur Rab Nishtar	Posts & Air
10.	Asaf Ali	Railways & Transport
11.	C. Rajagopalachari	Education & Arts
12.	I.I. Chundrigar	Commerce
13.	Ghaznafar Ali Khan	Health
14.	Joginder Nath Mandal	Law

Note: The members of the interim Government were members of the Viceroy's Executive Council. The Viceroy continued to be the head of the Council. But, Jawaharlal Nehru was designated as the Vice-President of the Council.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. When was the Interim Government of India formed?

It officially took office on **2 September 1946** , with **Jawaharlal Nehru as Vice-President of the Viceroy's Executive Council** .

2. What was the role of the Cabinet Mission Plan in the formation of the Interim Government?

The **Cabinet Mission Plan (1946)** proposed an Interim Government supported by major political parties and the formation of a **Constituent Assembly** .

3. When did the Muslim League join the Interim Government?

The Muslim League joined on **26 October 1946** , with **Liaquat Ali Khan appointed as Finance Member** .

4. Why was the Interim Government significant for India's independence?

It enabled **Indian leaders to exercise executive authority** , gain administrative experience and begin the transition from **colonial rule to self-government** .

5. How did the Interim Government contribute to Partition?

Persistent **Congress-Muslim League deadlock and administrative paralysis** strengthened the view among leaders that a united central government was becoming unworkable, contributing to acceptance of the **Mountbatten Plan, 1947** .

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. In the context of Colonial India, Shah Nawaz Khan, Prem Kumar Sehgal and Gurbaksh Singh Dhillon are remembered as (2021)

- (a) Leaders of Swadeshi and Boycott Movement
- (b) Members of the Interim Government in 1946
- (c) Members of the Drafting Committee in the Constituent Assembly
- (d) Officers of the Indian National Army

Ans: D

Q. With reference to the Cabinet Mission, which of the following statements is/are correct? (2015)

1. It recommended a federal government.
2. It enlarged the powers of the Indian courts.
3. It provided for more Indians in the ICS.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3
- (c) 1 and 3
- (d) None

Ans: A

Q. Which portfolio was held by Dr. Rajendra Prasad in the Interim Government formed in 1946? (2006)

- (a) Defence
- (b) External Affairs and Commonwealth
- (c) Food and Agriculture
- (d) None

Ans: C

Namami Gange Programme



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Government has highlighted the role of **Jan Ganga** , the public participation pillar of the **Namami Gange Programme** , in transforming river conservation from a government-led activity into a **people-driven movement** .

What are the Key Facts About the Namami Gange Programme (NGP)?

- **About:** The **Namami Gange Programme (NGP)** was launched in **2014** as a **Flagship Integrated Conservation Mission** for the **effective abatement of pollution, conservation, and rejuvenation of the National River Ganga and its tributaries** .
- **Integrated Approach:** The programme focuses not only on cleaning the river but also on **ecological restoration, biodiversity conservation, sustainable management, and improving the overall health of the river ecosystem** .
- **Implementation Framework:** The programme follows a phased approach through **Entry-Level Activities (immediate visible impact), Medium-Term Activities, and Long-Term Activities** for comprehensive river rejuvenation.
- **Community-Centric Approach:** Recognising that long-term river conservation requires public participation, NGP promotes **Jan Ganga** , based on the principle of **Jan Bhagidari** , to transform river conservation from a government initiative into a **people-driven movement** .
- **Major Focus Areas:** The programme covers activities such as **sewage treatment, riverfront development, afforestation, scientific monitoring, and public awareness campaigns** .

Key Achievements Under Namami Gange Programme

- **Project Implementation:** Under NGP, **524 projects have been sanctioned** , out of which **355 projects have been completed** , covering river rejuvenation, pollution control, and ecological restoration.
- **Biodiversity Conservation:** Scientific conservation initiatives have strengthened protection of aquatic species such as **Gangetic Dolphin** , **Gharial** , **turtles** , **Hilsa**, and **otters** through restoration, rescue, and rehabilitation programmes.
- **Ecosystem Restoration:** Forestry interventions along the Ganga basin have resulted in afforestation of around **33,024 hectares** , improving riverine ecology and biodiversity.
- **River Health Improvement:** CPCB monitoring shows improvement in water quality, with **pH and Dissolved Oxygen (DO) levels meeting bathing criteria across monitored locations of the Ganga** .

How does Community Participation under the Namami Gange Programme Promote River Conservation?

- **Jan Ganga Initiative:** **Jan Ganga** is the public participation pillar of the **Namami Gange Programme** , based on the principle of **Jan Bhagidari (people's participation)** . It aims to transform river conservation from a government-led activity into a **community-driven movement** by promoting

awareness, participation, and ownership.

- **River Cleanliness Drives:** Initiatives like **Ganga Swachhta Pakhwada (16-31 March)** encourage students, volunteers, community groups, and stakeholders across Ganga basin states to participate in cleanliness activities, making river conservation a regular civic responsibility.
- **Plantation and Riverbank Restoration:** Plantation campaigns such as “ **Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam** ” promote community involvement in tree plantation, helping in **riverbank stabilisation, reducing soil erosion, and restoring riverine ecosystems** .
- **Youth Engagement: University Ganga Clubs, eco-clubs, and educational institutions** involve youth through lectures, field visits, volunteering, competitions, and awareness programmes, creating long-term environmental responsibility.
- **Cultural and Awareness Programmes:** **Ganga Utsav** , along with initiatives like **Swachhta Hi Seva** and **International Day of Yoga** , strengthens the cultural connection between communities and rivers through exhibitions, performances, and public dialogues.
- **Community-Based Conservation Networks:** **Ganga Praharis** and **Ganga Seva Doots** work at the grassroots level to spread awareness, protect biodiversity, promote sustainable practices, and encourage local communities to become guardians of river ecosystems.
- **Innovative Outreach Initiatives:** Activities such as the **BSF all-women Ganga river rafting expedition** promote environmental awareness and create direct engagement between citizens and river conservation efforts.

Conclusion

The future of river conservation lies in combining scientific interventions, sustainable practices, and active community participation. Through **Jan Ganga, the Namami Gange Programme** has shown that lasting rejuvenation of the Ganga cannot be achieved by government efforts alone. By transforming citizens from passive observers into responsible stakeholders, the initiative paves the way for a more inclusive and sustainable model of river conservation, where communities become long-term guardians of their natural ecosystems.

Drishti Mains Question

River conservation cannot be achieved through government intervention alone and requires active community participation. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Namami Gange Programme?

Namami Gange Programme is an Integrated Conservation Mission launched in **2014** for pollution abatement, conservation and rejuvenation of the Ganga and its tributaries.

2. What is Jan Ganga?

Jan Ganga is the public participation pillar of the Namami Gange Programme that promotes community involvement in river conservation.

3. What is Ganga Swachhta Pakhwada?

Ganga Swachhta Pakhwada is an annual river cleanliness campaign observed from **16th to 31st March** to promote public participation in Ganga conservation.

4. Who are Ganga Praharis?

Ganga Praharis are grassroots community volunteers who support river conservation, biodiversity protection and environmental awareness.

5. What is the significance of Ganga Utsav?

Ganga Utsav is a flagship community engagement event celebrating the Ganga as India's National River through cultural programmes, exhibitions and public dialogue.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/nwrMaLeQppk](https://www.youtube.com/embed/nwrMaLeQppk)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ) *Prelims*

Q. Which of the following are the key features of 'National Ganga River Basin Authority (NGRBA)'? (2016)

1. River basin is the unit of planning and management.
2. It spearheads the river conservation efforts at the national level.
3. One of the Chief Ministers of the States through which the Ganga flows becomes the Chairman of NGRBA on rotation basis.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Water Hyacinth Menace in Vembanad Lake



Source: TH

The **State Wetland Authority Kerala (SWAK)** is launching a **one-month pilot project** at **Kumarakom, Kerala**, to control the spread of **invasive water hyacinth (*Eichhornia crassipes*)** in **Vembanad Lake** using **robotic technology**.

- **Government Framework:** The project is being implemented under the **National Plan for Conservation of Aquatic Ecosystems (NPCA)** of the **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)**.
- **Vembanad Lake:** It is a major **Ramsar Wetland Site** and one of the most important aquatic ecosystems of Kerala, supporting biodiversity, fisheries, tourism, and local livelihoods.

Water Hyacinth (*Eichhornia crassipes*)

- **Scientific Identity:** Water hyacinth (*Eichhornia crassipes*) is a **free-floating freshwater aquatic weed** belonging to the **Pontederiaceae family** and is an invasive alien species.
- **Origin:** It is **native to the Amazon Basin of South America** and was introduced in many countries, including India, as an **ornamental plant due to its attractive purple flowers** .
- **Rapid Growth and Spread:** Water hyacinth reproduces rapidly and forms dense floating mats, blocking sunlight penetration and reducing dissolved oxygen levels, thereby affecting aquatic biodiversity.
- **Impact on Ecosystem:** Excessive growth causes **eutrophication** and chokes rivers, lakes, ponds and wetlands, disrupting **fisheries, navigation, irrigation channels, tourism activities and recreational use** .
- **Management:** Controlled through **mechanical removal, biological control using Neochetina weevils, and reduction of nutrient pollution/sewage discharge** to prevent excessive growth.
- **Uses:** Can be utilised for **compost, bio-fertiliser, soil supplements, handicrafts, paper production, and phytoremediation** (removal of pollutants from water).



Read More: [Water Hyacinth](#)

Banks Seek CRR Cut on Green Deposits



Source: ET

In a significant move to accelerate India's transition towards a **net-zero** economy, public sector banks have approached the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) seeking a reduction in the **Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)** applicable to **green deposits**.

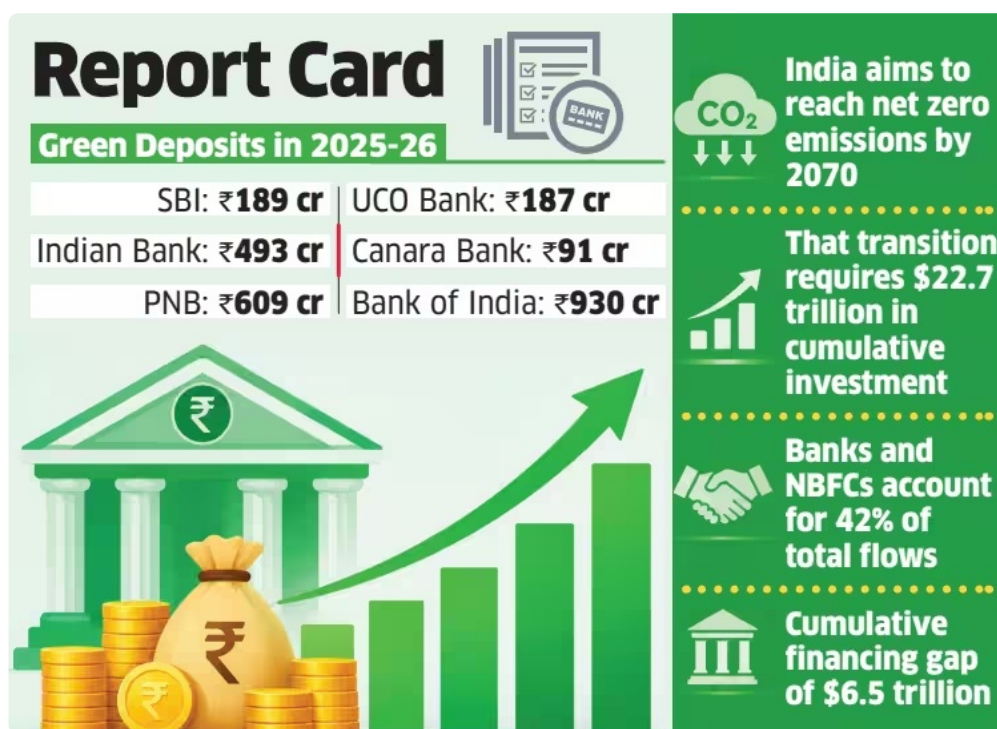
- **The Proposal:** Banks have advocated for an initial **CRR reduction of up to 100 basis points (1%)** on green deposits to make green lending cheaper and prioritize it as a preferred credit option.
- **Current Scenario:** Despite growth, green deposits raised in 2025-26 were only around **Rs 4,000-5,000 crore**, which is significantly below the critical mass required to fund India's climate goals.
 - According to the **NITI Aayog** report '**Scenario towards Viksit Bharat & Net Zero - Financing Needs**', India requires a massive **USD 22.7 trillion in cumulative investment** to successfully achieve its **net-zero transition**.
- **Rationale for Cut:** A lower CRR would **reduce funding costs** and free up capital, compensating banks for the **higher compliance costs** incurred in continuous project evaluation to prevent **greenwashing** (misuse of green funds).
 - To ease the burden on domestic **banks and NBFCs**, India must finalize its under-development

climate finance taxonomy and create a coordinated regulatory environment to attract **long-term global capital** .

- **Green Deposits:** A green deposit is an interest-bearing deposit received by a regulated entity (such as a bank or an NBFC) for a fixed period.
 - The proceeds from these deposits are earmarked strictly for allocation towards eligible green projects.
 - **Eligible Sectors:** Under the **RBI Green Deposit Framework 2023** , funds must be used for sectors like **renewable energy, waste management, clean transportation, climate change adaptation, and energy efficiency** .
 - Green Deposits differ from **Green Bonds** , which are debt securities issued to raise funds for eligible green projects.

Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)

- **Definition:** CRR is the percentage of a **bank's Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL)** that must be maintained as cash reserves with the RBI.
- **Interest:** Banks **do not earn any interest** on the money parked with the RBI under the CRR mandate.
- **Impact on Liquidity:** A high CRR drains excess liquidity from the banking system, reducing the banks' lending capacity. Conversely, a lower CRR frees up capital, allowing banks to lend more money to borrowers.



Read more: [Green Deposits](#)

Shakti Sharma Becomes 1st Non-Medical Woman Two-Star Officer



Source: PIB

Shakti Sharma has achieved a historic milestone by becoming the **first woman officer from the non-medical stream in the Indian Defence Forces to attain the rank of Air Vice Marshal or equivalent** . Air Vice Marshal (AVM) is a two-star rank in the Indian Air Force, equivalent to Major General in the Indian Army and Rear Admiral in the Indian Navy.

- **About:** She was commissioned into the **Education Branch of the Indian Air Force (IAF)** on **18th June 1994** and has completed over three decades of service.
- **Career:** During her career, she served in diverse roles across **training establishments, field stations, Command Headquarters, and Air Headquarters** , contributing to institutional development within the IAF.
- **Initiatives:** She played a key role in establishing **IAF Chairs of Excellence at IIT Kanpur and Pune University** to promote research, knowledge exchange, and strategic defence collaboration.
- **Milestones:** Before becoming Air Vice Marshal, she became the **first woman officer from the Tri-Services to command a Sainik School** , serving as the Principal of **Sainik School, Kapurthala** .
- **Significance:** The Indian Air Force expanded career opportunities for women officers after **granting Permanent Commission to women officers in selected branches from 2010** , enabling greater career progression and leadership opportunities.



Trailblazing Women in the Indian Air Force

Key Milestones by Women Officers



1. Air Marshal Padma Bandopadhyay



First woman Air Vice Marshal in the Indian Air Force; belonged to the Medical Branch and achieved the rank in 2002.



2. Group Captain Shaliza Dharmi



First woman officer to command a frontline combat unit in the Indian Air Force.



3. Squadron Leader Bhawana Kanth



First woman fighter pilot to complete the Fighter Combat Leader course.



4. Air Vice Marshal Shakti Sharma



First woman officer from the non-medical stream in the Indian Defence Forces to attain the rank of Air Vice Marshal or equivalent.

Read More: [Indian Air Force Day](#)

6th World Nomad Games



Source: IE

The **Prime Minister of India** attended the opening ceremony of the **6 th World Nomad Games in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan** , highlighting India's growing cultural and strategic engagement with Central Asia.

- **Origin & Evolution:** World Nomad Games established via the **2012 Bishkek Declaration** (Kyrgyzstan, Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Turkey) to promote the traditions, history and cultural heritage of nomadic peoples.
 - First held in 2014, the **World Nomad Games (WNG)** has evolved into a **UN-recognised biennial platform** for intercultural dialogue and sustainable development, attracting participants from **90+ countries** and hosted across regions including **Central Asia, Türkiye and Kazakhstan.**
- **Core Focus:** Distinct from the standard Olympics, the event emphasizes ancestral civilizational heritage over strict geopolitical ties, uniting nations to celebrate traditional nomadic survival practices like horseback riding, falconry, and indigenous wrestling.
- **Three Major Components:**
 - **Sports Programme:** Features traditional athletic and tactical games such as Kok Boru, Kurash, Goresh, Mongol Bokh, archery, and Toguz Korgool.
 - **Cultural Programme:** Showcases indigenous music, crafts, cuisine, and festivals. It is officially inscribed on the **UNESCO Register of Good Safeguarding Practices** under the project title "*Nomad Games: Rediscovering Heritage, Celebrating Diversity*" .
 - **Scientific Programme:** Dedicated to researching nomadic history, preserving traditional knowledge, and fostering intercultural dialogue.
- **Record Indian Participation (2026):** Fielded an 87-member contingent competing in traditional disciplines such as **Kurash, Goresh, Mongol Bokh** (wrestling), **Kok Boru** (equestrian), and **Toguz Korgool** (strategy board games).
 - **Kok Boru**, a traditional Kyrgyz **horseback game similar to polo** , recognised by **UNESCO as Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2017** .
- **Geopolitical Relevance for India:** Acts as a cultural diplomacy tool to advance strategic interests in Central Asia, including **post- Taliban security cooperation** , **countering Chinese influence** , securing **energy needs** , and promoting connectivity networks like the **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)** .

Read more: [Commonwealth Games 2026 and Future of Sports in India](#)